

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Medieval History 18 - The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

01 | The Deccan and the Mughals

DECCAN & THE MUGHALS TO 1657 | ORIGINAL STUDY VISUAL

1

1562-1657: entry, resistance, settlement, renewed intervention

2

A connected political economy, not a north/south binary

3

Evidence-led UPSC learning session

Interpretation aid: labels are evidence-led revision prompts, not a substitute for maps or primary sources.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

Medieval History 18 - The Deccan & the Mughals (to 1657) - Complete Topic Package

PART V - PYQ AUDIT, ROUTING AND PRACTICE

Transparent PYQ audit: 2018-2025 CSE

Audit result: No direct, exact and verifiably worded CSE Prelims or GS-I question for 2018-2025 was located in the repository's official/OCR/routing material on Mughal Deccan policy, Chand Bibi, Ahmadnagar, Malik Ambar, Khandesh/Asirgarh, Bijapur/Golconda, the 1636 treaties or early Maratha military groups.

This is a **PYQ gap**, not permission to invent a question, invent a key, or misroute a generic Deccan Plateau question. Mature Shivaji/Maratha questions belong primarily to Topic 23; broad Mughal administration questions belong to Topics 16/21; Qandahar belongs to Topic 19. No external/coaching wording is reproduced here as a CSE PYQ. If a future official paper is added, preserve original option order and label an absent official key as **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED** with source, confidence and elimination.

Adjacent routes (not direct Topic 18 PYQs)

Route	Owner	Why it is adjacent, not duplicated
Bahmani break-up, Deccani-afaqi setting, Talikota	Topic 09	Background political field; do not repeat its full Vijayanagara/Bahmani content
Akbar's northern consolidation and late expansion	Topic 15	Provides bridge to Khandesh/Deccan; Topic 18 owns the detailed southern policy
Qandahar/Safavid balance	Topic 19	Parallel frontier policy; use only for comparison of strategy and resources
Jahangir court and Nur Jahan	Topic 20	Court context; Topic 18 owns the Deccan command/policy analysis
Shah Jahan/mansabdari and jagir strain	Topic 21	Fiscal architecture; Topic 18 owns Deccan application and settlement
Aurangzeb's later wars	Topic 22	Outside the 1657 boundary
Shivaji, mature Maratha state and later Deccan crisis	Topic 23	Topic 18 supplies only the pre-Shivaji bridge

Current-affairs verification

No material recent official current-affairs anchor found; static and heritage relevance retained. A live official/UNESCO search covering 18 February-18 August 2026 found the UNESCO Tentative List description of *Monuments and Forts of the Deccan Sultanate* but no date-specific official conservation, status or policy development materially linked to this topic in the requested period. It is therefore heritage context, not a forced current-affairs card.

Static teaching link: History -> Medieval India -> Deccan Sultanates, route systems, state capacity and heritage-source method.

46 | Buffer-State Model

DECCAN & THE MUGHALS TO 1657 | ORIGINAL STUDY VISUAL

1 direct rule: higher extraction, high cost

2 suzerainty: tribute, hierarchy, lower cost

3 buffers absorb southern rivalries

4 risk: autonomous allies can grow stronger

Interpretation aid: labels are evidence-led revision prompts, not a substitute for maps or primary sources.

Buffer-State Model

Visual 46: Buffer-State Model. Use it to connect evidence with a causal argument; it is not to scale where marked.

57 | Source Matrix

DECCAN & THE MUGHALS TO 1657 | ORIGINAL STUDY VISUAL

1 Mughal Persian chronicles: court success narrative

2 Deccani/Marathi records: regional interests and retrospection

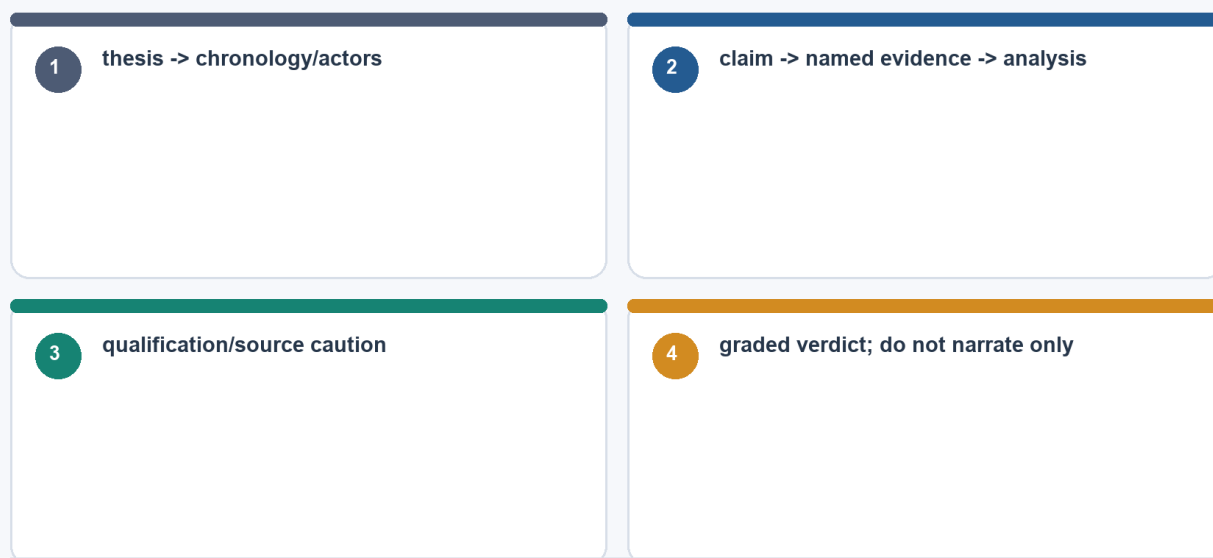
3 European reports: port/commercial lens

4 forts, coins, inscriptions, water systems: material checks

Interpretation aid: labels are evidence-led revision prompts, not a substitute for maps or primary sources.

Source Matrix

Visual 57: Source Matrix. Use it to connect evidence with a causal argument; it is not to scale where marked.



Interpretation aid: labels are evidence-led revision prompts, not a substitute for maps or primary sources.

Mains Answer Spine

Visual 60: Mains Answer Spine. Use it to connect evidence with a causal argument; it is not to scale where marked.

PART V - ADVANCED EVIDENCE LABS: HOW TO REASON, NOT MERELY RECALL

Lab 1. Reading a political map without turning it into a modern border map

The map for this topic should begin with routes rather than a colour-fill of kingdoms. Khandesh is meaningful because the Burhanpur-Asirgarh corridor linked northern mobilisation to plateau operations and to the Agra-Surat route. Berar and Balaghat matter because they gave an army an operational foothold and a contested field; Ahmadnagar matters because fort, capital, claimant and surrounding revenue links could come apart. Bijapur and Golconda were not two boxes waiting to be conquered but courts with rivals, resources and southern directions of expansion.

Evidence chain: Akbar's interest in Asirgarh, the 1601 incorporation of Khandesh, and the repeated need to sustain action beyond Ahmadnagar together show the difference between reaching the field and governing it. The later recovery under Ambar shows that a garrison's map did not automatically become a state map. This is why 'north versus south' is not an adequate answer structure.

Answer move: draw a small schematic arrow: Agra/Malwa -> Khandesh/Burhanpur -> Asirgarh -> Berar/Balaghat -> Ahmadnagar. Mark it **SCHEMATIC - NOT TO SCALE**, then add one sentence: control of the corridor reduced entry costs but did not replace supply, alliance or local legitimacy. This earns marks because it turns geography into a mechanism.

Qualification: the route was important, not exclusive. Maritime and coastal interests, local inland roads and Deccani court politics also altered the operational field. Do not say that whoever held Asirgarh controlled the whole Deccan.

Lab 2. Turning factionalism into explanation without making it a stereotype

Factions in this topic should not be reduced to ancient ethnic hatreds. Deccani, afaqi/gharib, Habshi and Afghan labels described differentiated locations in office, migration, military service and court access. Sunni/Shia language could sharpen contest, especially in particular court contexts, but political alliances still crossed labels when fort, jagir, marriage, office or survival required it. The Ahmadnagar succession crisis reveals this mechanism: Miyan Manju's invitation to the Mughals was an intra-court choice that opened space for an external force; Chand Bibi's coalition and later combined Deccani response show that categories could reassemble.

Evidence chain: the 1595-96 dispute, Chand Bibi's Habshi support, Bijapur-Golconda assistance at the frontier, and Ambar's later coalition all reject a simple Mughals-versus-the-South or Sunni-versus-Shia line. At the same time, factional instability mattered because it affected who controlled a claimant, a fort, a treasury and a negotiating position. It therefore changed capacity, not simply identity.

Answer move: write: 'Factionalism was an entry condition, not a sufficient cause of conquest.' Then show the sequence succession dispute -> invitation/pressure -> siege -> negotiated survival -> renewed coalition. This keeps Deccani actors politically active rather than treating them as passive victims of Mughal expansion.

Qualification: factionalism alone cannot explain Mughal intervention. Akbar's sovereign claims, strategic corridors, commercial concerns and army capacity all had to be present.

Lab 3. Chand Bibi as a case of constrained political agency

An examiner rewards a Chand Bibi answer that integrates gender, diplomacy and state crisis without turning her into an exception outside politics. Her link to both Ahmadnagar and Bijapur made her a plausible actor across courts. Her 1595-96 defence, requests for support and acceptance of the Berar settlement demonstrate that she assessed force and negotiated a survivable arrangement. The agreement recognised Bahadur under her regency while ceding Berar and accepting Mughal suzerainty. Its logic was preservation of a reduced Nizam Shahi order, not surrender of all political agency.

Evidence chain: the four-month siege and the proximity of Bijapur-Golconda forces help explain why the Mughals accepted compromise. The later dispute over Berar, noble divisions and the 1597 combined response help explain why it did not endure. During the second siege, Chand Bibi's attempt to negotiate a mansab and jagir position for Bahadur was read by a hostile faction as betrayal and led to her murder. The internal accusation is evidence that diplomacy in a siege could be politically fatal.

Answer move: use the three verbs **defended - negotiated - constrained**. Each takes a named example. Then conclude that agency did not remove structural limits: elite fragmentation and imperial pressure converted an intelligent survival bargain into a precarious position.

Qualification: sources often cast Chand Bibi in heroic language. Respect that memory while distinguishing court politics, treaty terms and later commemoration.

Lab 4. Malik Ambar: testing the phrase 'resistance'

Resistance is accurate only if it is made concrete. Malik Ambar used Nizam Shahi dynastic legitimacy, Habshi leadership, disbanded soldiers, Maratha bargis, support from Bijapur at key moments and local networks. His force moved rapidly, disrupted supplies and often avoided set battle. It could compel Mughal retreat and by about 1610 reverse the gains associated with Akbar in the assigned narrative. Such results demonstrate more than raiding: they required a political and revenue base.

Evidence chain: the 1601 pact with Khan-i-Khanan shows that Ambar also negotiated; the 1611 failure of converging Mughal commands shows how coordination became a target; the 1616-17 Mughal recovery shows that his methods did not make him invincible; Bhatari in 1624 shows a peak of coalition effectiveness. The source's 1627 death date and its balanced assessment are warnings against ending the story at a single victory.

Answer move: use a double verdict. First, Ambar exposed the gap between Mughal conquest and consolidation. Second, he could not overcome the contradictions of shifting allies and conflict with Bijapur; Ahmadnagar ended in 1633. This avoids both 'hero who saved the state' and 'adventurer who achieved nothing'.

Qualification: 'guerrilla' must be explained as an analytic shorthand. It does not establish a modern insurgent ideology, a uniform military manual or automatic national consciousness.

Lab 5. Revenue claims: how to avoid false precision

Revenue is the bridge between warfare and state capacity, but it is also where invented precision is most damaging. Later Marathi evidence attributes to Malik Ambar measurement of land, settlement of rates, village boundaries and measures, while the assigned account associates this with a move from ijara to zabti-type arrangements. These statements can support a claim of administrative reconstruction aimed at cultivation, local order and a more regular fiscal base.

They cannot support claims that he reproduced Todar Mal's system exactly, measured every village on an identical schedule, imposed a certain universal share, or created a modern land-record regime. The source itself says the scale of land-revenue demand is not precisely known, even when it notes a common assumption. A good historian differentiates an attributed policy from a verified uniform outcome.

Answer move: write measurement/rates -> predictable claims -> cultivation/local intermediaries -> military resources, then add the source limit. Tie desh mukhs to this explanation: their local position could help information, collection and order, but also gave them bargaining power. That makes revenue a political relationship rather than a spreadsheet.

Qualification: Mughal jagir and mansab mechanics belong in detail to Topics 16 and 21. Here, use fiscal strain only to explain why distant Deccan campaigns and imperfectly realised revenue made direct rule costly.

Lab 6. Shah Jahan's 1636 settlement as institutional design

The strongest interpretation of 1636 is neither 'peace treaty' nor 'conquest completed'. It was institutional design after the removal of the Nizam Shahi centre. Bijapur accepted a hierarchy of suzerainty, indemnity, non-interference in Golconda, imperial arbitration and a Shahji condition; it also gained from the division of Ahmadnagar. Golconda accepted Shah Jahan's name in the khutba, removal of the Iranian sovereign's name and tribute in return for protection. The details assign relation, not uniform provincial bureaucracy.

Evidence chain: Ahmadnagar's fall in 1633 created the opportunity; the continued danger of resistance showed why an inexpensive frontier solution mattered. The post-1636 expansion of Bijapur and Golconda in Karnataka shows the states retained initiative. Mughal neutrality and arbitration could sustain an order because they offered a credible umpire while limiting direct administration.

Answer move: compare two columns: annexation: officials, garrisons, revenue management, high cost and suzerainty: recognition, tribute, arbitration, buffer autonomy. State that 1636 selected the second model after force made it possible. Then state the coercion: the language was hierarchical and backed by threat; equal modern sovereignty is anachronistic.

Qualification: named treaty sums should never be supplied from memory. Source-grounded terms matter more than decorative figures.

Lab 7. Why the 1656-57 breach was more than a new campaign

The 1656-57 interventions matter because they altered expectations created by 1636. A buffer that expands southward under a settled hierarchy may tolerate tribute and arbitration; it becomes less secure when protection becomes a basis for compensation and territorial demand. Satish Chandra links the changed stance to Mughal Deccan financial difficulties, claims upon southern gains, the Golconda tribute/exchange dispute and the Bijapur succession crisis after Muhammad Adil Shah's death. Mir Jumla's position and Aurangzeb's vicereignty supplied further leverage and debate.

Evidence chain: the final 1657 arrangements did not simply fulfil an old accord. Bijapur was made to yield former Nizam Shahi areas, and Golconda faced Karnataka-linked demands. The source distinguishes Aurangzeb's expansive preferences from Shah Jahan's more variable, often limited objectives, and treats definitive claims about Dara with caution. Such disagreement is itself evidence of contested imperial policy.

Answer move: write credible buffer terms -> southern growth -> imperial fiscal/territorial claims -> intervention -> distrust. Conclude that the issue was credibility and capacity as much as battlefield success.

Qualification: stop before 1658. The later war of succession and Aurangzeb's full Deccan wars explain consequences, but including them as accomplished facts violates the topic's chronology.

Lab 8. A source-method answer can be a state-capacity answer

When a question asks about sources, do not detach method from substance. Persian Mughal chronicles can identify imperial claims, campaign sequence and the rhetoric of order, but their patronage may turn limited gains into totalised success. Deccani Persian materials can reveal rival claims and negotiation, but a regional writer's boundary statement demands comparison. Marathi memory may preserve local administrative practices but can be retrospective. European reports illuminate commercial and port worlds but privilege what merchants could see and value.

Material traces change the question. Asirgarh and Daulatabad show why forts required sieges, stores and route control; coins and khutba practices reveal claims of hierarchy; urban/water works may corroborate administrative context if identified and dated carefully. Court paintings, such as Jahangir's symbolic treatment of Ambar, reveal how the ruler wanted power imagined.

Answer move: for each source, say **what it can prove, what it cannot prove, and what checks it needs**. End with a synthetic conclusion: Mughal capacity was real enough to occupy forts and impose terms, but uneven because supplies, local intermediaries, faction and treaty credibility determined whether a claim could be sustained.

Qualification: bias is not a reason to discard a source. It is information about purpose, audience and silence.

Lab 9. Portuguese pressure: strategic context, not a diversion into maritime history

Portuguese power belongs in this topic because it affected the strategic imagination around Gujarat, Surat, the Konkan and pilgrim shipping. After the conquest of Gujarat, Akbar encountered a maritime order in which cartazes regulated ships and Diu customs constrained traders. Satish Chandra records both accommodation - Portuguese commercial privileges at Cambay and passes for royal pilgrim ships - and persistent humiliation or conflict. An attempted anti-Portuguese project did not proceed because effective sea power was lacking.

Evidence chain: this context helps explain why a wider relationship with Deccan states and the western coast could matter to an inland empire. It also prevents an implausible claim that Akbar's southern policy had only a land-revenue motive. However, Portuguese pressure did not cause the Ahmadnagar succession crisis, and it does not explain every Mughal-Deccan campaign. The 1591 missions, the 1595 crisis and the Khandesh gateway have their own political logic.

Answer move: add Portuguese pressure as one line under 'strategic-commercial motives', then return immediately to the Deccan field. A well-controlled sentence is: 'Western coastal pressure heightened the value of Deccan leverage, but did not replace the central motives of hierarchy, route security and factional opportunity.' This avoids both extremes: ignoring seaborne power and converting a land politics answer into an early-colonial trade essay.

Qualification: European sources tell us much about permits, ports and trade, but are not sufficient evidence for inland elite motivations. Use Mughal and Deccani materials, as well as the material geography of routes and forts, to keep the frame balanced.

Lab 10. Comparing three emperors without flattening policy into personality

Akbar, Jahangir and Shah Jahan faced connected but changing problems. Akbar formulated a claim to all-India suzerainty, tried 1591 diplomacy, and used the Ahmadnagar crisis to gain Berar, Khandesh, Asirgarh and an Ahmadnagar foothold. The outcome was strategically meaningful but incomplete. Jahangir inherited resistance rather than a blank slate. His commanders and Prince Khurram recovered ground, yet the source interprets his refusal to expand gains as a deliberate limit on commitments, reinforced by diplomacy to detach allies.

Shah Jahan's early policy was sharper: the continued Ahmadnagar challenge, Khan-i-Jahan Lodi episode and claimant politics led him to seek the dynasty's extinction, achieved at Daulatabad in 1633. Yet he did not immediately absorb Bijapur and Golconda. The 1636 system retained them as hierarchy-bound buffers. Only later did fiscal strain, compensation claims, the Golconda and Bijapur crises and a more interventionist Deccan viceroyalty fracture the compact.

Answer move: build a three-row table: Akbar - entry/foothold; Jahangir - recovery/restraint; Shah Jahan - extinction/buffer settlement/breach. Then state the shared structural constraint: local coalitions, routes and cost. This is stronger than saying one emperor was strong and another weak, because it joins ruler choice to inherited conditions.

Qualification: individual decision matters, but it does not erase the capacity problem. A later ruler could choose renewed intervention only because the buffer states remained resourceful and the Mughal Deccan needed continued financial and military management.

Lab 11. Annexation, revenue potential and realised control

The phrase 'the Deccan was rich' is too imprecise for a Mains answer. Revenue potential mattered: Berar, Ahmadnagar zones, trade corridors and later southern expansion could promise resources. Yet an imperial state received usable revenue only after information, local cooperation, assessment, collection, security and distribution worked. A fort captured in a campaign could require a garrison; a jagir with an inflated assessment could yield less than nominal value; a long line of communication could consume the very resources sought.

Evidence chain: Ambar's recovery after Mughal gains, the need for Khandesh-Burhanpur logistical control, and Shah Jahan's later Deccan financial difficulty show why potential should not be confused with realised control. Topic 21's month-scale and jagir material provides a cross-link: it should be used to explain pressures, not copied as a full mansabdari essay. The source's account of Deccan financial disputes between Shah Jahan and Aurangzeb further signals that administration, not merely conquest, was the problem.

Answer move: write a small equation in words: territory claimed - cost of control = uncertain usable surplus. Then name one fort-route example and one coalition example. The formula is an analytical aid, not a historical statistic; do not put invented totals beside it.

Qualification: it is equally wrong to claim that Mughal rule yielded nothing. The empire did obtain footholds, tribute, territory and political leverage. The argument is about uneven, contestable capacity rather than automatic failure.

Lab 12. Memory, ethics and historical precision

This topic is often recruited into moralised stories: Chand Bibi becomes an isolated heroine; Malik Ambar becomes either a timeless racial symbol or a simple precursor of modern nationalism; Mughal-Deccan relations become a ready Hindu-Muslim binary. Such stories can preserve memory and signal why the past matters, but UPSC history must identify their evidentiary limits. Chand Bibi's significance increases, not decreases, when her regency, negotiations and factional adversaries are made visible. Ambar's Ethiopian/Habshi origin deserves accurate acknowledgement of displacement and enslavement, while his later political life must be located in Deccan institutions, coalition-making and ambition.

Evidence chain: court chronicles, Deccani narratives, later Marathi records, paintings and material sites speak from different purposes. A painting can show the imperial desire to dominate an enemy; a later record can preserve an administrative memory; a fort can reveal strategic geography. None alone authorises an all-purpose nationalist verdict. The political crossing of alliances among Habshi, Deccani, Maratha, Bijapuri and Mughal actors is especially important corrective evidence.

Answer move: include one sentence of source method after a memorable figure: 'Heroic memory is historically important, but the treaty, faction and material setting show a more complex agency.' This gives balance without cynical dismissal.

Qualification: avoid false neutrality. Respectful language about enslavement, gendered commemoration and regional memory is compatible with rigorous proof; it is the method by which historical dignity is protected.

Lab 13. Causal chronology: how not to turn dates into a dead list

A reliable chronology for this topic is an argument about changing relationships. Start with the 1562-64 Khandesh contacts: these establish connection and caution against reading a fully designed southern conquest into every early move. The 1576 Khandesh submission is the first clear owner-source point of Mughal acceptance there, but it is not all-Deccan submission. The 1591 missions then reveal a tested hierarchy. The 1595-96 Ahmadnagar succession crisis creates the junction at which diplomatic failure, factional invitation and Mughal preparation become military intervention.

The 1596 Berar settlement should be read as an interim structure: it holds together Chand Bibi's regency, a reduced Nizam Shahi claim and Mughal suzerainty. Its failure produces the 1597 combined Deccani response and eventually the 1600 fall of Ahmadnagar fort. The 1601 capture of Asirgarh and Khandesh creates a route base at precisely the moment when a remaining Nizam Shahi claimant and Malik Ambar demonstrate that a capital fort does not exhaust a state. Thus 1596 -> 1601 is not a one-way conquest line; it is a shift from negotiation to partial foothold.

The next sequence changes the question from entry to consolidation. By 1610 Ambar has recovered much of the field in the source account. The 1616-17 Mughal successes recover gains, but Jahangir limits expansion. The 1624 Bhaturi victory captures Ambar's high prestige, while his 1627 death removes an unusually capable coordinator. Shah Jahan's 1633 Daulatabad victory ends the dynasty yet produces a fresh claimant problem under Shahji. The 1636 treaties solve that problem indirectly by redesigning the political field around buffers.

Finally, 1636 -> 1657 is the movement from credible restraint to damaged credibility. Southern expansion by Bijapur and Golconda, Mughal fiscal worries, compensation claims and the 1656-57 interventions change the terms under which buffers had operated. This causal ladder lets a student use dates as evidence of policy change rather than as decorative chronology.

Answer move: use only five dates in a short answer - 1591, 1596, 1600-01, 1633, 1636 - and explain the policy transition between each. In a long answer add 1610/1617 and 1656-57 to show the problem of consolidation and breach. **Qualification:** date labels vary in secondary accounts; where the owner source gives a clear event, preserve its wording and flag contested nomenclature rather than invent precision.

Lab 14. Designing a high-scoring comparison answer

Comparison questions on the Deccan usually fail because they compare labels rather than capacities. A better comparison sets Akbar's foothold policy beside Jahangir's restraint, or direct annexation beside suzerainty, or Mughal column warfare beside Ambar's mobile coalition. Begin by stating a common problem: how to claim hierarchy over a region where local courts, forts and service networks retained resources. Then assign each side a mechanism.

For example, **Akbar versus Jahangir:** Akbar's 1591 missions and 1600-01 captures sought entry and a strategic base; Jahangir's 1616-17 recovery consciously stopped short of deeper expansion. The difference is not courage versus weakness. It is an assessment of commitment after Ambar showed the cost of holding ground. **Annexation versus suzerainty:** annexation demands officials, garrisons, revenue administration and durable supply; suzerainty seeks tribute, symbolic recognition and arbitration through still-autonomous buffers. The 1636 system selected the latter after the fall of Ahmadnagar.

For **Mughal versus Ambar capacity**, do not call one conventional and the other irrational. Mughal power could organise siege and concentrated campaigns; Ambar's coalition could choose movement, local intelligence and supply disruption. The 1611 coordination failure and 1616-17 recovery together establish that both capability and limitation existed. The conclusion should be graded: neither side possessed an automatic solution because alliances and revenue conditions kept changing.

Answer move: end each comparison with a two-line judgement: 'The contrast is therefore not binary. It shows that political hierarchy required a fit between military method, logistical reach and the chosen form of rule.' This sentence is reusable only when followed by named evidence; without it, it becomes empty formula.

Lab 15. Fifty-second answer-planning checklist

Before writing, fix the boundary at 1657 and identify the relationship being asked about: entry, foothold, resistance, settlement or breakdown. Select two named events and one mechanism. For motives, use 1591 missions plus Khandesh/Asirgarh and explain hierarchy, route and cost. For resistance, use Ambar's coalition plus the 1611 or 1616-17 evidence and explain supply/coordination. For settlement, use 1633 and the two 1636 ahdnamas and distinguish suzerainty from annexation. For breakdown, use 1656-57 and explain credibility, fiscal pressure and widening ambition.

Then add one qualification: source naming caution for Sonepat/Sonpet, later Marathi evidence caution for revenue, painting-as-symbol caution, or the limit that a fort's fall is not immediate territorial obedience. End with a graded verdict, never a slogan. This compact routine keeps a Mains answer chronological, analytical and source-aware.

Lab 16. Building a state-capacity answer across military, fiscal and diplomatic dimensions

State capacity in the Deccan should be treated as a relationship between resources and the ability to convert them into durable political effect. An emperor could order a campaign, but the order became power only if commanders coordinated, routes stayed open, pay and grain arrived, forts held, a claimant could be managed, local intermediaries cooperated and neighbouring courts did not create an alternative coalition. This framework explains why the same Mughal empire could take Asirgarh in 1601, recover ground in 1616-17, end Ahmadnagar's dynasty in 1633, and still repeatedly face renewed difficulty.

Military dimension: a concentrated imperial army could conduct sieges and impose settlement terms. Asirgarh and Daulatabad show material force against fortified nodes. Yet Ambar's mobile cavalry and supply-cutting made a field army's material superiority less decisive when it depended on long corridors. The 1611 failure of two converging Mughal commands exposes coordination as a capacity variable, not a minor anecdote. The 1616-17 recovery shows that the issue was not a permanent inability to campaign, but the conditions under which campaigns produced durable results.

Fiscal dimension: direct possession promised revenue but also garrisons, officers, communication and the risk of imperfectly realised assessment. Ambar's attributed revenue reconstruction points to the other side of capacity: a regional state also needed predictable claims, cultivation and local law/order. Under Shah Jahan, fiscal difficulties in the Mughal Deccan helped turn a buffer settlement into pressure for compensation. Avoid invented totals; the analytical distinction is potential revenue versus usable surplus after cost.

Diplomatic dimension: 1591 missions, the 1596 Berar agreement, Jahangir's effort to detach Bijapur and the 1636 ahdnamas all show that capacity included making other rulers recognise a credible hierarchy. Suzerainty could extract symbolic recognition, tribute and arbitration at lower cost than annexation. Its weakness was credibility: when 1656-57 demands altered the apparent bargain, buffers had reason to distrust protection.

Answer move: build a four-box diagram: force -> logistics -> revenue -> credible settlement, then draw an arrow back from local coalition/mobile resistance to logistics and settlement. Use one event for each box: 1601, 1611, Ambar's revenue evidence, 1636. The conclusion should be measured: Mughal power was formidable but unevenly convertible; the Deccan exposed the difference between winning access, holding territory and securing consent.

Lab 17. What an evidence-led conclusion should and should not say

The conclusion to a Deccan answer must resolve a tension rather than repeat a slogan. It should not say that the Mughals simply failed: Akbar acquired Khandesh and Asirgarh, Jahangir's forces recovered positions in 1616-17, Shah Jahan ended the Nizam Shahi dynasty and the 1636 settlement obtained real recognition. Nor should it say that the Mughals simply succeeded: Ambar's recovery, recurring claimant politics, the cost of long supply lines and the breach of 1656-57 show that a claim of hierarchy did not guarantee stable rule.

Use a graded statement such as: 'Between 1591 and 1657 Mughal policy repeatedly converted strategic opportunity into footholds and negotiated hierarchy, but it could not eliminate the regional coalitions, logistical burdens and credibility problems that made direct control more costly than suzerainty.' This conclusion is defensible because each clause has evidence: 1591 missions and 1600-01 foothold; Ambar and the 1611 coordination problem; 1636 buffers; 1656-57 renewed intervention.

The qualification should be tailored. In a Chand Bibi answer, add that heroic memory must not eclipse factional politics. In an Ambar answer, add that mobile warfare did not make every Mughal campaign fail. In a 1636 answer, add that the pact was coercive and asymmetric even while it was pragmatic. In a source answer, add that bias reveals purpose rather than making evidence useless.

Such a conclusion earns marks because it carries the reasoning of the body forward. It does not force a teleology in which later Aurangzeb outcomes are assumed to have been inevitable in 1657, and it does not use hindsight to erase the contingent choices of Akbar, Jahangir, Shah Jahan, Chand Bibi, Ambar, Shahji, Bijapur and Golconda.

Lab 18. From a fort narrative to a regional-system argument

Fort-centred narrative is unavoidable in the Deccan, but it is incomplete if the fort appears only as a trophy. Asirgarh, Ahmadnagar and Daulatabad should each be read as a junction of military position, route access, provisions, a court's legitimacy and the surrounding ability to collect or deny resources. This is why their captures are major events and why none automatically resolves the political field.

Asirgarh's 1601 surrender enabled Khandesh's incorporation and strengthened the Burhanpur gateway. Its significance lay in access to the Deccan and the commercial corridor, not in a magical capacity to make Bijapur and Golconda obedient. Ahmadnagar fort's capture in 1600 gave the Mughals an important position and Balaghat claim, but Murtaza II, Ambar and remaining networks made state continuity possible. Daulatabad's 1633 fall ended the Nizam Shahi dynasty in formal terms, yet Shahji's claimant project and Bijapuri help revealed that dynastic extinction was not identical with the immediate disappearance of armed authority.

This approach also improves a source answer. A Persian chronicle may celebrate a fort's surrender because it serves an imperial success narrative. A Deccani source may preserve the persistence of a claimant. The physical fort can show why siege and storage mattered but cannot itself prove every political motive. Bringing these materials together prevents either side from monopolising the meaning of capture.

Answer move: make a four-column mini-table: fort | immediate event | system function | post-capture limit. Fill it with Asirgarh/1601/gateway/partial control; Ahmadnagar/1600/foothold/Ambar recovery; Daulatabad/1633/dynastic centre/Shahji claimant. This is compact value addition in a 15- or 20-marker.

Qualification: not every route or garrison relation is precisely documented in the same source. State what the evidence supports, and never infer a detailed operational map merely because a fort was famous. The analytic payoff is still strong: the Deccan demonstrates that an empire's map is made of connected systems, not just captured places.

Evidence cards for answer enrichment

Card 1. Connectivity

Claim: The Vindhyas were a frictional zone, not an absolute political wall. **Named evidence:** Tughlaq-era movement, Sufi/employment migration and Malwa-Khandesh routes. **What it proves:** Explains why Mughal entry was conceivable before it was successful. **Qualification:** Do not deny the real logistical effect of terrain. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 2. Khandesh

Claim: Gateway geography turned Burhanpur and Asirgarh into strategic assets. **Named evidence:** Agra-Surat corridor and 1601 incorporation. **What it proves:** Connects fort capture to provisioning, trade and operational depth. **Qualification:** A gateway did not itself pacify the plateau. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 3. 1591 diplomacy

Claim: Akbar tested hierarchy through missions before force. **Named evidence:** Khandesh accepted clearly; other courts offered limited courtesy. **What it proves:** Shows escalation was contingent, not automatic conquest. **Qualification:** Presents are not proof of submission. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 4. Chand Bibi

Claim: The Berar treaty was negotiated survival. **Named evidence:** Defence, regency and 1596 cession under pressure. **What it proves:** Restores political agency to a factional crisis. **Qualification:** Avoid romantic memory as sole evidence. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 5. Sonapat name

Claim: Source terminology must not be converted into false geography. **Named evidence:** Sonapat/Supa/Sonpet in Berar-Deccan context. **What it proves:** Demonstrates provenance-aware use of campaign names. **Qualification:** Never identify it with Haryana Sonipat without evidence. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 6. Ambar

Claim: Coalition, not ethnicity alone, explains recovery. **Named evidence:** Habshi leadership, claimant, Bijapur support and bargis. **What it proves:** Shows how local political capacity challenged garrison rule. **Qualification:** Do not call Ambar a Maratha ruler. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 7. Logistics

Claim: Operational supply links state capacity to warfare. **Named evidence:** 1611 coordination failure and mobile supply cutting. **What it proves:** Explains why strong armies could still lose control. **Qualification:** Do not claim Mughals never won in the Deccan. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 8. Revenue

Claim: Administrative reconstruction is a source-qualified capability claim. **Named evidence:** Later Marathi references to measurement and rates. **What it proves:** Links fiscal practice to cultivation and local order.

Qualification: No exact universal revenue figure is secure. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 9. Jahangir

Claim: Restraint can be a policy, not a synonym for impotence. **Named evidence:** 1616-17 recovery and refusal to enlarge Akbar's gains. **What it proves:** Shows cost-conscious imperial strategy. **Qualification:** Reverses and resistance still matter. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 10. Daulatabad

Claim: Dynastic fall and territorial obedience are different processes. **Named evidence:** 1633 surrender followed by Shahji/claimant activity. **What it proves:** Shows why forts, legitimacy and networks must be separated. **Qualification:** Do not imply resistance vanished. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 11. 1636

Claim: Suzerainty allowed hierarchy without full administrative burden. **Named evidence:** Bijapur arbitration condition; Golconda khutba/tribute. **What it proves:** Explains a buffer-state solution. **Qualification:** It was coercive, not equal sovereignty. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Card 12. 1656-57

Claim: A treaty fails when its limits are reinterpreted through extraction. **Named evidence:** Compensation/tribute dispute, succession crisis and territorial demands. **What it proves:** Shows breach of credibility before the later wars. **Qualification:** Stop before 1658 and later annexations. **Use in an answer:** Open a paragraph with the claim, give the evidence, explain the mechanism, then use the qualification to avoid overstatement.

Practice diagnostics: turning errors into better answers

Use each card after attempting a question. It identifies a specific failure, a repair, evidence and the examiner-facing gain.

Diagnostic 1. Scope control

Common failure: A draft ends with Aurangzeb's 1686-87 annexations. **Repair:** Stop at 1657; use later wars only as a one-line forward bridge. **Evidence anchor:** 1656-57 interventions damaged the 1636 settlement but precede the succession war. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is chronological discipline.

Diagnostic 2. Relationship vocabulary

Common failure: A draft calls Golconda a Mughal province in 1636. **Repair:** Replace province with suzerainty/protection and explain khutba, tribute and retained court. **Evidence anchor:** Golconda retained internal rule while accepting Shah Jahan's name and protection arrangement. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is to separate hierarchy from annexation.

Diagnostic 3. Gender and agency

Common failure: A draft says Chand Bibi fought bravely and stops. **Repair:** Add regency, factional crisis, appeal for support, Berar bargain and hostile-faction murder. **Evidence anchor:** Her 1596 settlement preserved Bahadur under regency under severe pressure. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is political agency rather than ornamental heroism.

Diagnostic 4. Map reasoning

Common failure: A draft lists Asirgarh without explanation. **Repair:** Connect it to Khandesh, Burhanpur, Agra-Surat route, provisioning and entry. **Evidence anchor:** Akbar's 1601 acquisition secured a gateway rather than the entire plateau. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is route-market-logistics analysis.

Diagnostic 5. Coalition analysis

Common failure: A draft calls Ambar a Maratha ruler. **Repair:** Name him as a Habshi/Nizam Shahi leader and identify Maratha cavalry as part of a coalition. **Evidence anchor:** Habshi, Deccani, Afghan, Bijapuri and Maratha elements supported different phases. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is actor precision.

Diagnostic 6. Military method

Common failure: A draft calls all Ambar's war guerrilla warfare. **Repair:** Define the shorthand: mobility, intelligence and supply cutting; add its historical limit. **Evidence anchor:** The 1611 Mughal command failure and 1616-17 recovery show contingent capacity. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is avoiding modern equivalence.

Diagnostic 7. Revenue evidence

Common failure: A draft gives Ambar a fixed revenue rate as certain. **Repair:** State the later Marathi provenance and separate attributed reform from verified uniform outcome. **Evidence anchor:** Measurement, rates and boundaries are remembered; scale is not precisely known in the source. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is source-qualified fiscal analysis.

Diagnostic 8. Jahangir judgement

Common failure: A draft equates restraint with helplessness. **Repair:** Pair reverses with 1616-17 recovery and deliberate refusal to enlarge commitments. **Evidence anchor:** Satish Chandra's interpretation treats limited aims as a strategic choice. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is balanced evaluation.

Diagnostic 9. Fort and state

Common failure: A draft says Ahmadnagar ended when its fort fell. **Repair:** Distinguish fort capture, claimant legitimacy, local networks and remaining territory. **Evidence anchor:** Murtaza II/Ambar politics and later Shahji resistance show continuity after centres fall. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is a layered state-capacity model.

Diagnostic 10. Treaty analysis

Common failure: A draft praises 1636 as permanent peace. **Repair:** Explain its buffer benefits and the risk of ambiguous/contested limits. **Evidence anchor:** Bijapur and Golconda could expand southward while still accepting Mughal hierarchy. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is a qualified verdict.

Diagnostic 11. Late Shah Jahan

Common failure: A draft asserts Dara caused the 1656-57 reversal. **Repair:** Mark Dara's role as inconclusive in the assigned source and focus on documented pressures. **Evidence anchor:** Fiscal difficulty, compensation claims, succession crisis and Aurangzeb's preference are safer evidence. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is avoiding false certainty.

Diagnostic 12. Source method

Common failure: A draft treats Jahangir's Ambar painting as a battle report. **Repair:** Read it as imperial representation and ask what a court image wants to claim. **Evidence anchor:** Symbolic shooting of an image asserts mastery, not literal encounter. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is genre awareness.

Diagnostic 13. PYQ integrity

Common failure: A draft labels a generic Shivaji question a Topic 18 CSE PYQ. **Repair:** Record it as an adjacent route unless exact wording/year/provenance are verified. **Evidence anchor:** The audit found a direct 2018-25 repository gap for this topic. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is honest provenance.

Diagnostic 14. Mains conclusion

Common failure: A draft concludes 'Mughals failed in Deccan'. **Repair:** Replace with a graded claim about partial control, treaty adaptation and renewed dilemma. **Evidence anchor:** Khandesh/Asirgarh, 1617 restraint and 1636 settlement prove real but conditional capacity. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is rejecting binary success/failure.

Diagnostic 15. Rapid outline

Common failure: A 15-marker has no internal spine. **Repair:** Use three headings: entry and foothold; resistance and logistics; settlement and limit. **Evidence anchor:** Place 1591/1600-01, Ambar/1611, and 1633/1636 under the respective headings. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is visible structure.

Diagnostic 16. Option elimination

Common failure: An MCQ calls the 1596 arrangement a total surrender. **Repair:** Test each word: Berar was ceded, but Bahadur was recognised under regency and suzerainty. **Evidence anchor:** The treaty preserved a reduced Ahmadnagar claim while giving a Mughal foothold. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is to reject absolute language.

Diagnostic 17. Nomenclature control

Common failure: An answer uses 'Deccan' as one homogeneous kingdom. **Repair:** Name Ahmadnagar, Bijapur, Golconda, Bidar and Khandesh where relevant, then locate their rivalries. **Evidence anchor:** Sholapur, Berar and Karnataka disputes show why a single-block model fails. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is actor-level precision.

Diagnostic 18. Causation control

Common failure: An answer says revenue caused every campaign. **Repair:** Use a multi-causal formulation: sovereignty, route security, factional opportunity, commerce and potential revenue. **Evidence anchor:** The 1591 missions and 1595 succession crisis prove political triggers as well as material interests. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is avoiding monocausal explanation.

Diagnostic 19. Evidence density

Common failure: A 20-marker gives only dates. **Repair:** For each paragraph add a named person/event and tell what it proves. **Evidence anchor:** For example: Chand Bibi/1596 proves negotiated survival; Ambar/1611 proves logistics; 1636 proves buffer design. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is claim-evidence-analysis rather than narration.

Diagnostic 20. Final revision

Common failure: A student memorises terms but cannot apply them. **Repair:** Ask one question for each: annexation, occupation, suzerainty, protection, arbitration and alliance. **Evidence anchor:** Use the 1636 system to classify relations rather than merely define words. **Examiner gain:** The mark-saving action is conceptual transfer in unfamiliar questions.

Learning MCQ Loop (18)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Which formulation best captures Akbar's initial Deccan objective?

A. Obtain recognition of Mughal over-lordship while allowing local rule under conditions B. Immediate provincial annexation of every sultanate C. A permanent equality treaty among sovereign states D. Withdrawal from all western-coast concerns

Answer: A. Obtain recognition of Mughal over-lordship while allowing local rule under conditions
Explanation: The Rajasthan-style suzerainty model explains why diplomacy preceded selective force.

Q2. Why was Khandesh strategically important?

A. It was the only source of Deccani horses B. Burhanpur and Asirgarh connected routes, markets and a gateway to the plateau C. It contained the capital of Golconda D. It eliminated the need for siege logistics

Answer: B. Burhanpur and Asirgarh connected routes, markets and a gateway to the plateau
Explanation: The closest distractor is 'horse supply'; route and gateway logic is the source-grounded reason.

Q3. The 1596 Ahmadnagar settlement did which of the following?

A. Ended all Nizam Shahi authority B. Made Ahmadnagar a Mughal province C. Ceded Berar while recognising Bahadur under Chand Bibi's regency and Mughal suzerainty D. Transferred Bijapur to Mughal rule

Answer: C. Ceded Berar while recognising Bahadur under Chand Bibi's regency and Mughal suzerainty
Explanation: It was a negotiated survival arrangement, not a full conquest.

Q4. The 1597 battle called Sonepat/Supa/Sonpet in the assigned source should be handled how?

A. As a battle at Sonipat in Haryana B. As an unimportant coastal skirmish C. As a certain location with a fixed modern spelling D. As a Deccan/Berar campaign event whose nomenclature must not be confused with Sonipat

Answer: D. As a Deccan/Berar campaign event whose nomenclature must not be confused with Sonipat
Explanation: Source nomenclature is uncertain; the secure context is the combined Deccani response in Berar.

Q5. Which statement about Chand Bibi is most defensible?

A. She was a political actor who defended, negotiated and governed under factional constraint B. She was only a romantic battlefield icon C. She independently annexed Bijapur D. She ended Mughal interest in Berar

Answer: A. She was a political actor who defended, negotiated and governed under factional constraint
Explanation: Her Bijapur and Ahmadnagar links make the 'only warrior-queen' description inadequate.

Q6. Akbar's 1600-01 gains are best described as:

A. The permanent conquest of all Deccan sultanates B. A foothold in Ahmadnagar/Balaghat plus Khandesh/Asirgarh, not complete Deccan control C. A treaty that made Golconda a Mughal province D. A coastal Portuguese alliance

Answer: B. A foothold in Ahmadnagar/Balaghat plus Khandesh/Asirgarh, not complete Deccan control

Explanation: The key discriminator is partial control: Bijapur and Golconda still did not submit.

Q7. Malik Ambar should be identified as:

A. A Maratha king who founded Shivaji's state B. A Mughal mansabdar permanently loyal to Jahangir C. A Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics who used a multi-group coalition including Maratha cavalry D. A Portuguese commander at Surat

Answer: C. A Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics who used a multi-group coalition including Maratha cavalry

Explanation: His Ethiopian/Habshi origin and Nizam Shahi office rule out the Maratha-ruler shortcut.

Q8. Why is 'guerrilla warfare' a cautious label for Ambar's methods?

A. It proves a modern nationalist insurgency B. It means Ambar never used forts or diplomacy C. It describes European naval tactics D. It is shorthand for mobility and supply disruption, not a modern equivalence

Answer: D. It is shorthand for mobility and supply disruption, not a modern equivalence
Explanation: The source describes rapid cavalry and supply cutting; present-day political meanings should not be projected backward.

Q9. What is the safest account of Ambar's revenue policy?

A. Later Marathi evidence attributes measurement and zabti-type changes, but uniform details are uncertain B. He copied Todar Mal's system exactly everywhere C. No revenue policy is associated with him D. It established a modern cash tax state

Answer: A. Later Marathi evidence attributes measurement and zabti-type changes, but uniform details are uncertain
Explanation: The source limit is the point: attribution is useful without claiming identical, universal reform.

Q10. Jahangir's restraint after 1617 primarily indicates:

A. That he lacked any army in the Deccan B. A deliberate wish to avoid enlarged commitments after recovering Akbar-era gains C. That he annexed Bijapur D. That Malik Ambar permanently surrendered

Answer: B. A deliberate wish to avoid enlarged commitments after recovering Akbar-era gains
Explanation: Satish Chandra explicitly treats restraint as policy rather than simple military failure.

Q11. The painting of Jahangir shooting Malik Ambar's image is best used as:

A. A report of an actual assassination B. Proof that Ambar never fought the Mughals C. Evidence of imperial symbolism and claimed dominance D. A neutral map of Deccan boundaries

Answer: C. Evidence of imperial symbolism and claimed dominance
Explanation: A court painting can reveal representation; it cannot be read as literal event reportage.

Q12. Bhatari (1624) matters because:

A. It ended all Mughal campaigns in India B. It was an English factory treaty C. It marked Daulatabad's surrender D. It raised Ambar's prestige after victory over a combined Mughal-Adil Shahi force in the source narrative

Answer: D. It raised Ambar's prestige after victory over a combined Mughal-Adil Shahi force in the source narrative
Explanation: The closest distractor is Daulatabad, but that belongs to 1633 and Shah Jahan's phase.

Q13. The fall of Daulatabad in 1633 demonstrates:

A. Dynastic extinction did not automatically end local resistance or claimant politics B. That Bijapur was annexed C. That Shahji stopped changing service D. That 1636 terms had already been imposed

Answer: A. Dynastic extinction did not automatically end local resistance or claimant politics Explanation: Shahji's subsequent claimant project shows why fort fall and field control must be separated.

Q14. The 1636 arrangements with Bijapur and Golconda are best classified as:

A. A direct annexation settlement B. Coercive Mughal suzerainty/protection leaving buffer states intact C. An equal modern treaty without hierarchy D. A Portuguese maritime alliance

Answer: B. Coercive Mughal suzerainty/protection leaving buffer states intact Explanation: Khutba, tribute and arbitration denote hierarchy, while the sultanates retained their courts.

Q15. Which is an accurate Golconda term in the assigned source?

A. Golconda abolished all Persianate links B. Golconda ceded every port to the Mughals C. Shah Jahan's name entered the khutba while the Iranian sovereign's was removed, alongside tribute/protection D. Golconda became a Mughal province in 1636

Answer: C. Shah Jahan's name entered the khutba while the Iranian sovereign's was removed, alongside tribute/protection Explanation: The political signal was changed sovereign recognition, not immediate provincial administration.

Q16. Why was the 1636 settlement statesmanlike in the source's assessment?

A. It eliminated every local elite network B. It required no military pressure C. It stopped all Deccan expansion southward D. It stabilised a frontier through buffers and hierarchy at lower direct Mughal cost

Answer: D. It stabilised a frontier through buffers and hierarchy at lower direct Mughal cost Explanation: The settlement combined coercion with limited aims; its advantages were strategic and fiscal.

Q17. The 1656-57 interventions should be interpreted as:

A. A break in the restraint that had sustained the 1636 spirit B. Proof that 1636 had annexed Bijapur and Golconda C. A completed later-Aurangzeb conquest D. A war of succession episode after 1658

Answer: A. A break in the restraint that had sustained the 1636 spirit Explanation: They undermined the buffer compact before the later succession war and full annexation era.

Q18. Which conclusion best fits the whole topic?

A. The Deccan was isolated until Mughal armies arrived B. Mughal policy was always uniform conquest C. Maratha nationalism was created by one person D. B. Entry, partial control, mobile resistance, treaty and renewed intervention formed a changing capacity problem

Answer: B. Mughal policy was always uniform conquest Explanation: This causal sequence explains both imperial gains and the costs of keeping them.

Broad Topic MCQs (40)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Which statement best expresses the principal lesson of north-south connectivity?

A. A connected corridor system of trade, migration, pilgrimage and war B. A sealed boundary at the Vindhya C. A purely coastal relationship D. No pre-Mughal interaction

Answer: A. A connected corridor system of trade, migration, pilgrimage and war Explanation: Long-distance movement preceded the Mughals; the false 'sealed Vindhya boundary' option erases routes, migration and pilgrimage.

Q2. Which statement best expresses the Faruqi Khandesh location in strategy?

A. Burhanpur-Asirgarh gateway to routes and operations B. A substitute for Berar revenue C. A Golconda port D. A Maratha capital

Answer: B. A substitute for Berar revenue Explanation: Burhanpur and Asirgarh mattered as a linked gateway. Horse supply was important in Deccan politics but is not the reason assigned to Khandesh here.

Q3. Which statement best expresses the risk of treating sect as a full explanation?

A. It removes factional competition B. It ignores office, local rivalry and cross-label alliances C. It makes all alliances easy to predict D. It proves all Deccan courts were identical

Answer: C. It makes all alliances easy to predict Explanation: Sectarian affiliation mattered in some courts, yet office, rivalry and expediency changed partnerships; 'alliance is predictable' is therefore the faulty shortcut.

Q4. Which statement best expresses the 1591 mission outcome?

A. Bijapur became a Mughal province B. Portugal joined the Mughals C. Khandesh clearly submitted while other responses were limited/courteous D. Every court accepted direct annexation

Answer: D. Every court accepted direct annexation Explanation: The 1591 missions produced one clear Khandesh acceptance, not annexation or a Portuguese alliance; courtesy elsewhere did not equal submission.

Q5. Which statement best expresses the main political error in a Chand Bibi answer?

A. Mentioning factionalism B. Treating her only as a romantic heroine C. Not calling Berar a port D. Recognising her negotiation

Answer: A. Mentioning factionalism Explanation: Calling Chand Bibi only a romantic heroine suppresses regency and negotiation; her political work is the exact missing dimension.

Q6. Which statement best expresses the significance of Berar?

A. It supplied a Mughal foothold that alarmed Deccan neighbours B. It became a permanent Portuguese base C. It ended Ahmadnagar immediately D. It was equivalent to all the Deccan

Answer: B. It became a permanent Portuguese base Explanation: Berar mattered because it supplied a forward Mughal foothold; the claim that it ended Ahmadnagar immediately confuses cession with extinction.

Q7. Which statement best expresses the secure reading of 1600?

A. All Nizam Shahi territory was pacified B. Golconda was annexed C. Ahmadnagar fort fell but Nizam Shahi resistance continued D. Akbar had ceased to intervene

Answer: C. Ahmadnagar fort fell but Nizam Shahi resistance continued Explanation: The fort's fall did not exhaust Nizam Shahi legitimacy or territory; the option saying resistance ended ignores the claimant-Ahmadnagar recovery.

Q8. Which statement best expresses the source-critical Asirgarh conclusion?

A. Only a bribery story can be mentioned B. Siege/pestilence/surrender are in the assigned account; alternatives need provenance C. The fort did not matter D. Every capture story has identical evidence

Answer: D. Every capture story has identical evidence Explanation: The assigned siege-pestilence-surrender narrative can be used, but exclusive reliance on a bribery story ignores the source-critical problem.

Q9. Which statement best expresses Ambar's coalition?

A. Only Habshi troops and no allies B. Only Maratha rulers C. Nizam Shahi legitimacy, Habshis, Deccanis, Bijapur support and Maratha networks D. Only Portuguese naval aid

Answer: A. Only Habshi troops and no allies Explanation: Ambar's coalition joined legitimacy, Habshi leadership, Bijapuri support and Maratha resources; 'only Maratha rulers' makes the key category error.

Q10. Which statement best expresses a Mughal logistical weakness?

A. Total absence of cavalry B. Distance, supply, monsoon and command coordination C. Lack of forts in India D. No access to revenue

Answer: B. Distance, supply, monsoon and command coordination Explanation: A campaign's supplies, weather and command coherence are concrete constraints; 'absence of cavalry' is neither the source's point nor plausible.

Q11. Which statement best expresses the value of deshmukh networks?

A. They joined local authority to service and armed following B. They were European companies C. They were irrelevant to revenue or mobilisation D. They ended court faction

Answer: C. They were irrelevant to revenue or mobilisation Explanation: Deshmukh ties connected local authority with revenue and mobilisation; calling them irrelevant removes the interface that made service networks valuable.

Q12. Which statement best expresses the safe claim about Khirki?

A. It was founded by Shivaji in 1674 B. It was a Mughal capital under Akbar C. It proves a verified uniform water reform D. It is associated with an Ambar-era Nizam Shahi centre

Answer: D. It is associated with an Ambar-era Nizam Shahi centre Explanation: Khirki is safely an Ambar-era Nizam Shahi centre; a verified universal water reform is an unsupported escalation from an urban association.

Q13. Which statement best expresses the 1616-17 sequence?

A. Mughal victories recovered gains, yet did not end resistance B. Jahangir annexed every Deccan state C. Ambar died D. the 1636 treaty occurred

Answer: A. Mughal victories recovered gains, yet did not end resistance Explanation: The 1616-17 sequence illustrates recovery without final resolution; 'Jahangir annexed every state' makes a limited campaign into total conquest.

Q14. Which statement best expresses Jahangir's farzand language?

A. A declaration of equality without claims B. A diplomatic effort to manage Bijapur within hierarchy C. A Portuguese title D. a revenue survey

Answer: B. A diplomatic effort to manage Bijapur within hierarchy Explanation: Farzand was hierarchical diplomacy aimed at managing Bijapur; it was not a declaration that Mughal claims had vanished.

Q15. Which statement best expresses the 1621 cycle?

A. Shows a final peace after 1596 B. Creates the Nizam Shahi dynasty C. Shows repeated military pressure and unstable settlements D. occurs after 1636

Answer: C. Shows repeated military pressure and unstable settlements Explanation: The 1621 cycle belongs to recurring pressure and unstable settlement; it cannot be treated as a final peace after 1596.

Q16. Which statement best expresses the balanced Ambar assessment?

A. Resistance/state reconstruction alongside shifting alliances and inability to save Ahmadnagar permanently B. Only betrayal; no achievement C. A simple modern nationalist story D. Only heroism; no political limits

Answer: D. Only heroism; no political limits Explanation: Ambar's reconstruction and resistance were real, but permanent survival failed; the 'only heroism' option loses the necessary limitation.

Q17. Which statement best expresses Shahji's historical value here?

A. He illustrates shifting service and claimant politics B. He was an independent Mughal emperor C. He ended all Bijapuri links D. He is interchangeable with Shivaji

Answer: A. He illustrates shifting service and claimant politics Explanation: Shahji demonstrates shifting service and claimant politics; he was neither a Mughal emperor nor a static opponent of every court.

Q18. Which statement best expresses the primary aim of Shah Jahan's early policy?

A. Annex every southern state immediately B. Extinguish Ahmadnagar as a persistent source of instability C. Give up Khandesh D. Return Berar

Answer: B. Extinguish Ahmadnagar as a persistent source of instability Explanation: Shah Jahan's early target was Ahmadnagar as an unresolved security problem, not immediate absorption of all southern kingdoms.

Q19. Which statement best expresses the Daulatabad result?

A. Golconda annexed in 1633 B. the 1657 settlement C. Nizam Shahi dynastic end in 1633 but not instant social/military pacification D. Mughal departure from Khandesh

Answer: C. Nizam Shahi dynastic end in 1633 but not instant social/military pacification Explanation: Daulatabad ended the dynasty but did not dissolve resistance; equating the event with Golconda's annexation is a chronology and category error.

Q20. Which statement best expresses Bijapur's 1636 relation to Golconda?

A. Full annexation of Golconda B. a union of the two states C. withdrawal from Karnataka D. Non-interference plus future imperial arbitration

Answer: D. Non-interference plus future imperial arbitration Explanation: Bijapur's promise of non-interference and arbitration arranged relations with Golconda; it did not empower Bijapur to annex it.

Q21. Which statement best expresses the political import of khutba/sikka?

A. They can signal hierarchy and sovereign recognition B. They automatically prove modern citizenship C. They are only artistic forms D. They end local administration

Answer: A. They can signal hierarchy and sovereign recognition Explanation: Khutba and sikka indicate recognised hierarchy in political language; they do not automatically create modern citizenship or erase administration.

Q22. Which statement best expresses the buffer-state argument?

A. It guarantees loyalty forever B. It can lower direct administrative costs while sustaining hierarchy C. It removes all need for diplomacy D. It is annexation

Answer: B. It can lower direct administrative costs while sustaining hierarchy Explanation: Buffers could transmit tribute and hierarchy at less direct cost; their value is not a guarantee of permanent loyalty.

Q23. Which statement best expresses post-1636 southern expansion?

A. The Deccan became economically inactive B. Mughals directly ruled every southern town C. Bijapur and Golconda expanded into Karnataka under treaty space D. Europeans controlled all internal routes

Answer: C. Bijapur and Golconda expanded into Karnataka under treaty space Explanation: Post-1636 southern campaigns by the buffer states are central; the claim of economic inactivity reverses the treaty-space consequence.

Q24. Which statement best expresses the use of European commercial reports?

A. Treat them as neutral nationwide census B. Ignore all Mughal sources C. Use them to prove every fort capture D. Use them with a coastal/commercial provenance caution

Answer: D. Use them with a coastal/commercial provenance caution Explanation: European commercial reports must be read through their coastal-commercial lens, not treated as a neutral census of inland Deccan.

Q25. Which statement best expresses the 1656 Golconda trigger?

A. A mix of tribute/exchange, compensation and Mir Jumla context B. A mature Shivaji treaty C. Daulatabad's 1633 siege D. a 1591 embassy

Answer: A. A mix of tribute/exchange, compensation and Mir Jumla context Explanation: Golconda intervention combined tribute/exchange and compensation claims with the Mir Jumla setting; it is not a retrospective Shivaji episode.

Q26. Which statement best expresses the 1657 Bijapur crisis?

A. Direct annexation had already been completed B. Muhammad Adil Shah's death and Mughal claims enabled pressure C. It came after Aurangzeb's 1687 conquest D. It ended the war of succession

Answer: B. Muhammad Adil Shah's death and Mughal claims enabled pressure Explanation: Muhammad Adil Shah's death created a usable Bijapur crisis; full annexation had not already occurred and would belong to later history.

Q27. Which statement best expresses Shah Jahan's late aims?

A. They were proven identical to Aurangzeb's B. They never involved territory C. They were contested and could fall short of Aurangzeb's full-annexation ambition D. They are known only from European reports

Answer: C. They were contested and could fall short of Aurangzeb's full-annexation ambition Explanation: The source separates Aurangzeb's expansive preference from Shah Jahan's variable aims; asserting identity erases that policy debate.

Q28. Which statement best expresses the state-capacity causal loop?

A. Conquest -> permanent peace without cost B. Trade -> no politics C. Sect -> automatic annexation D. Factional opening -> foothold -> resistance -> costly partial control -> treaty -> renewed intervention

Answer: D. Factional opening -> foothold -> resistance -> costly partial control -> treaty -> renewed intervention Explanation: The causal loop includes resistance and treaty after entry; the 'permanent peace' alternative misses why 1656-57 mattered.

Q29. Which statement best expresses the right overextension conclusion by 1657?

A. A growing risk and process, not an already inevitable completed collapse B. The Mughal Empire had ended C. No fiscal issue existed D. The Deccan had no effect on administration

Answer: A. A growing risk and process, not an already inevitable completed collapse Explanation: By 1657 overextension was a developing risk, not an empire already ended; the answer must preserve this temporal distinction.

Q30. Which statement best expresses a limitation of Persian court chronicles?

A. They have no chronology at all B. Patronage can privilege imperial success and hierarchy C. They are European coastal sources D. They can never be used

Answer: B. Patronage can privilege imperial success and hierarchy Explanation: Court patronage can encourage a success narrative, not make Persian chronicles worthless; the latter is an overcorrection.

Q31. Which statement best expresses a limitation of later bakhars?

A. They are automatically fabricated B. They are Mughal farmans C. Retrospection and local loyalty require provenance checks D. They are all contemporary battle maps

Answer: C. Retrospection and local loyalty require provenance checks Explanation: Later bakhars can preserve useful local memory, but retrospective loyalty requires checking; automatic fabrication is not method.

Q32. Which statement best expresses a material source contribution?

A. They make texts unnecessary B. They prove every motive C. They have no chronology D. Forts, inscriptions, coins and water works can complement texts

Answer: D. Forts, inscriptions, coins and water works can complement texts Explanation: Material remains complement texts by locating claims in forts, coins and works; they do not remove the need for textual comparison.

Q33. Which statement best expresses a memory/history distinction?

A. Heroic remembrance can coexist with evidence-based qualification B. Memory must always replace evidence C. Only nationalist frames matter D. Sources have no genre

Answer: A. Heroic remembrance can coexist with evidence-based qualification Explanation: Remembrance can illuminate why a figure matters, but it cannot replace evidence; the correct option combines both rather than choosing one.

Q34. Which statement best expresses the Topic 18 boundary?

A. Narrate Aurangzeb to 1707 fully B. Stop at 1657 and route later annexation/mature Shivaji to later topics C. End at Talikota D. Ignore Maratha bridge

Answer: B. Stop at 1657 and route later annexation/mature Shivaji to later topics Explanation: Topic 18 ends at 1657, so later Aurangzeb and mature Shivaji material is a route, not its narrative endpoint.

Q35. Which statement best expresses the best Mains structure?

A. A date list alone B. A single heroic anecdote C. Thesis, named evidence, causal analysis, qualification and verdict D. Unqualified generalisation

Answer: C. Thesis, named evidence, causal analysis, qualification and verdict Explanation: A direct thesis plus evidence, analysis and qualification answers an unfamiliar directive; a date list offers no causal judgement.

Q36. Which statement best expresses the function of forts?

A. They remove all supply needs B. They belong only to culture C. They make diplomacy redundant D. They are nodes in route-market-logistics systems, not decorative points

Answer: D. They are nodes in route-market-logistics systems, not decorative points Explanation: Forts are strategic nodes because they relate to corridors, markets and supplies; treating them as decorations loses their operational function.

Q37. Which statement best expresses the significance of Burhanpur?

A. It was a capital/gateway and provisioning-commercial node B. It was Golconda's port C. It was outside Khandesh D. It did not matter to campaigns

Answer: A. It was a capital/gateway and provisioning-commercial node Explanation: Burhanpur combined capital/gateway/provisioning functions; it was not Golconda's port and cannot be omitted from Khandesh strategy.

Q38. Which statement best expresses the distinction between occupation and annexation?

A. They always mean the same thing B. An occupied fort can precede or differ from durable administrative incorporation C. Occupation is a cultural term D. Annexation means only tribute

Answer: B. An occupied fort can precede or differ from durable administrative incorporation Explanation: Occupation can be militarily real before administration is durable; the options treating it as identical to annexation or mere culture fail.

Q39. Which statement best expresses the prerequisite for claiming a direct PYQ?

A. A similar generic Deccan geography question B. A coaching recollection C. Exact verified wording and provenance D. A mature Shivaji question

Answer: C. Exact verified wording and provenance Explanation: A direct PYQ requires exact wording and provenance; similarity to generic geography or a coaching recollection is not verification.

Q40. Which statement best expresses the correct closing boundary?

A. Topic 18 must narrate events through Aurangzeb's death B. The narrative ends at 1636 because treaties never changed C. The 1657 events are irrelevant to later dilemmas D. The 1656-57 crisis is analysed, then later full annexation and mature Shivaji conflict are routed forward

Answer: D. The 1656-57 crisis is analysed, then later full annexation and mature Shivaji conflict are routed forward Explanation: The 1656-57 breach is the final analysed event because it creates, rather than completes, the later Deccan dilemma; the alternatives either overrun or truncate the set boundary.

Remedial MCQs (12)

The correct options rotate independently. Solve before opening each explanation; every explanation identifies the deciding distinction.

Q1. Did Akbar conquer the whole Deccan?

A. No. His gains were important but partial: Khandesh, Berar/Balaghat and Ahmadnagar fort did not equal Bijapur/Golconda submission. B. A. No: he secured a foothold, not the whole Deccan C. Yes, in 1601 D. Yes, by the 1591 missions

Answer: A. No. His gains were important but partial: Khandesh, Berar/Balaghat and Ahmadnagar fort did not equal Bijapur/Golconda submission. Explanation: Yes, through 1636

Q2. What is wrong with a 'warrior-queen only' account of Chand Bibi?

A. It hides regency, factional management, correspondence and negotiation under pressure. B. She had no political role C. B. It erases her political agency beyond battlefield memory D. It overstates her links with Bijapur

Answer: B. She had no political role Explanation: It makes Berar too important

Q3. Was Malik Ambar a Maratha ruler?

A. No. He was a Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics who mobilised Maratha military networks. B. He was Shahji C. He was a Mughal prince D. C. No: coalition leadership is not the same as Maratha rulership

Answer: C. He was a Mughal prince Explanation: He was a Portuguese captain

Q4. Does 'guerrilla' mean modern insurgency here?

A. No. It is a limited analytic label for mobility, terrain and supply disruption. B. It describes a twentieth-century ideology C. It excludes diplomacy D. It proves nationalism

Answer: D. It proves nationalism Explanation: D. No: it is shorthand, not a modern equivalence

Q5. Did 1636 annex Bijapur and Golconda?

A. No. The arrangements imposed hierarchy, tribute/protection and arbitration while leaving buffer states intact. B. A. No: suzerainty/protection is not direct annexation C. Yes, because tribute equals province D. Yes, because of khutba alone

Answer: A. No. The arrangements imposed hierarchy, tribute/protection and arbitration while leaving buffer states intact. Explanation: Yes, because of later wars

Q6. Did Shah Jahan always seek full Deccan conquest?

A. No. His early policy was bounded by Ahmadnagar; later objectives became more expansive and contested. B. He never intervened C. B. No: aims changed from a bounded settlement to later demands D. He annexed all states in 1633

Answer: B. He never intervened Explanation: He left all claims to Bijapur

Q7. Was Jahangir's Deccan policy simple military failure?

A. No. Satish Chandra treats post-success restraint as a deliberate avoidance of deeper commitments. B. He had no commanders C. He ended all campaigns D. C. No: deliberate restraint followed recovery of gains

Answer: C. He ended all campaigns Explanation: He had no interest in hierarchy

Q8. Is Sonapat/Sonpet the Haryana city Sonipat?

A. No. The source's variable name belongs to a Deccan/Berar campaign and must be locationally cautioned. B. Yes, it is the Haryana city C. It is a Portuguese port D. It is Daulatabad

Answer: D. It is Daulatabad Explanation: D. No: do not convert source nomenclature into a false modern location

Q9. Did Ahmadnagar fort's fall end resistance?

A. No. Claimants, mobile forces and local networks continued after a fort/dynastic centre fell. B. A. No: state capacity persisted beyond the fort C. Yes, all territory surrendered D. Yes, Shahji vanished

Answer: A. No. Claimants, mobile forces and local networks continued after a fort/dynastic centre fell. Explanation: Yes, Bijapur was annexed

Q10. Did one person create Maratha nationalism?

A. No. Ambar, Shahji and later Shivaji belong to different stages of employment, networks and state formation. B. Ambar alone created it C. B. No: avoid a one-man nationalist origin story D. Shah Jahan created it

Answer: B. Ambar alone created it Explanation: The Portuguese created it

Q11. Were Deccan alliances simply Sunni versus Shia?

A. No. Office, faction, rivalry and strategic interest repeatedly crossed religious/ethnic labels. B. They were always sectarian C. They had no sectarian dimension D. C. No: sect mattered, but never explains the whole field alone

Answer: C. They had no sectarian dimension Explanation: Only Europeans chose alliances

Q12. Do 1657 events belong to the later full Aurangzeb wars?

A. They are the boundary and bridge: they reopened the dilemma but precede the succession war and later annexations. B. They are after 1687 C. They settle the Deccan permanently D. They are unrelated to the 1636 compact

Answer: D. They are unrelated to the 1636 compact Explanation: D. They are a pre-succession spillover, not the later-war narrative

Examiner-grade Original Mains Practice (10 solved answers)

Mains 1. 10 marks | Examine the motives and evolution of Mughal policy in the Deccan up to 1636. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: explain motives and change, not a list of battles.

Model solution: Mughal policy evolved from an all-India claim of hierarchy toward selective force and a low-cost settlement. Akbar's 1591 missions show that over-lordship was first sought by diplomacy; Khandesh's response, unlike the limited courtesy elsewhere, gave a corridor foothold. The Burhanpur-Asirgarh route and Gujarat-Surat connection made security and commerce material motives, while Deccani factionalism offered opportunities. The 1596 Berar cession and 1600-01 gains secured positions but did not create full rule: Bijapur and Golconda remained outside submission, and Ahmadnagar resistance revived.

Jahangir recovered gains but, after Khurram's 1617 campaign, deliberately avoided enlarged commitments. Shah Jahan then treated independent Ahmadnagar as the unresolved source of instability, ended its dynasty at Daulatabad (1633), and used the 1636 ahdnamas to make Bijapur and Golconda accept suzerainty. Thus policy was neither a timeless conquest drive nor mere glory: it balanced hierarchy, security, routes and cost. **Qualification:** military pressure made the settlement coercive, not an equal compact.

Why this earns marks: It answers evolution with four named anchors and distinguishes suzerainty from annexation.

Mains 2. 10 marks | Assess Chand Bibi's role in the Ahmadnagar crisis of 1595-1600. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: assess agency within constraints rather than write a heroic biography.

Model solution: Chand Bibi was a political actor whose agency was real but constrained by succession conflict and imperial pressure. After Burhan Nizam Shah's death and Ibrahim's death in war, Miyan Manju backed a pretender while Chand Bibi, linked to both Ahmadnagar and Bijapur, supported infant Bahadur with the Habshi party. Her defence during the 1595-96 siege, appeal for support and acceptance of the Berar settlement show command, diplomacy and regency rather than a merely romantic warrior image.

The settlement preserved Bahadur under her guardianship but conceded Berar and Mughal suzerainty. It was a survival bargain made amid a strong Bijapur-Golconda presence, not proof of free choice. Later noble divisions, disputes over Berar and the combined response in 1597 made the arrangement untenable. During the second siege she explored a subordinate settlement for Bahadur and was killed by a hostile faction on a charge of treachery.

Verdict: Chand Bibi delayed collapse and displayed political judgement, but could not overcome the internal fragmentation that enabled Mughal intervention.

Why this earns marks: It integrates succession, treaty, agency and factional qualification.

Mains 3. 10 marks | Explain why Khandesh and Asirgarh mattered more than as mere conquests. Answer in 150 words.

Directive alignment: explain strategic function through geography and logistics.

Model solution: Khandesh was a gateway system, not a decorative northern edge of the Deccan. Its capital Burhanpur lay on the corridor linking northern Mughal power to the plateau and on the Agra-Surat/western trade route. Asirgarh, reputed a formidable fort, protected access to this route-and-market complex. Their capture in 1601 therefore gave the Mughals a base for provisioning, movement, intelligence and pressure on Deccani states.

The point is demonstrated by the contrast with Ahmadnagar: capturing a fort did not itself create durable regional control, whereas a corridor could sustain campaigns only if routes, supplies and allies remained available. Satish Chandra's account of siege, pestilence and surrender supports the capture narrative; competing traditions should be marked source-dependent. **Qualification:** Khandesh reduced entry costs but did not solve monsoon, distance, local resistance or command coordination. Thus it enabled a foothold, not automatic mastery of the entire Deccan.

Why this earns marks: It uses Burhanpur, Asirgarh and the route-supply mechanism instead of a bare location fact.

Mains 4. 15 marks | Evaluate Malik Ambar as both a defender of Ahmadnagar and a maker of Deccan political possibilities. Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: evaluate achievement, mechanism and limitation.

Model solution: Malik Ambar defended Nizam Shahi survival by converting fragmented resources into a working coalition, while his methods widened the political space available to Maratha military elites. An Ethiopian/Habshi who rose through Deccan service, he became chief minister/regent for a Nizam Shahi claimant and drew together Habshi leadership, disbanded Deccani soldiers, Bijapuri support at key moments, Maratha bargis and local deshमुख links. By about 1610, this coalition had reversed Akbar's recent gains in the assigned account.

His military method used rapid cavalry, terrain, intelligence and attacks on supplies. It exposed Mughal vulnerabilities of distance, monsoon, forage, siege needs and divided commands; the failed 1611 converging operation is evidence. Later Marathi evidence also attributes measurement, rates and limits on ijara to him, suggesting state reconstruction, though it cannot establish a uniform Todar Mal copy. Bhatnuri (1624) demonstrates his peak prestige.

Yet Ambar did not permanently secure Ahmadnagar. His shifting alliances, conflict with Bijapur and refusal to stabilise settlements weakened a united front; Shah Jahan ended the dynasty in 1633. **Verdict:** he was neither a simple national precursor nor only an adventurer: he was an exceptional coalition-builder whose success delayed consolidation and developed regional military capacity, but could not settle the structural contest.

Why this earns marks: It treats origin respectfully, names evidence and balances recovery with failure.

Mains 5. 15 marks | How did mobile warfare expose limits in Mughal state capacity in the Deccan? Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: connect military method to capacity rather than call every raid guerrilla warfare.

Model solution: Mobile warfare did not prove that Mughal arms were ineffective; it showed that battlefield victory and durable control required different capacities. Ambar's forces used rapid mounted movement, local intelligence, terrain and supply-cutting, often avoiding a set battle on unfavourable terms. Satish Chandra associates this mode with Maratha bargis and notes that Mughals were less accustomed to it. The result was delay, re-routing and higher cost for imperial columns dependent on grain, fodder, pay, messages and siege stores.

Distance from northern bases, monsoon conditions and the fort-route-market system magnified this effect. The 1611 plan of Khan Jahan Lodi and Abdullah Khan shows a second weakness: mutual wrangling and failed coordination could undo numerical strength. Conversely, the 1616-17 Mughal successes show that alliances, capable command and concentrated pressure could recover territory. Thus the argument is not environmental determinism.

Qualification: 'guerrilla' is a cautious analytic shorthand, not a modern insurgency label. **Verdict:** the Deccan tested logistics, jagir-backed military resources, command integration and local alliances; it made conquest possible but consolidation contingent and expensive.

Why this earns marks: It gives a causal mechanism, named campaign evidence and a conceptual caution.

Mains 6. 15 marks | Discuss the pre-Shivaji Maratha bridge without reading later nationalism backward. Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: explain continuity and discontinuity.

Model solution: Pre-Shivaji Maratha power developed through service, local authority and regional competition rather than a ready-made nationalist programme. Deccani courts employed Maratha bargis as mobile cavalry and relied on desh mukh networks that joined landed influence, revenue claims and armed followers. Ahmadnagar, Bijapur and Mughal courts all offered office and jagir, allowing families to shift service in response to opportunity and threat.

Malik Ambar's coalition created employment, military experience and confidence for such groups, but he was a Habshi leader in Nizam Shahi politics, not a Maratha ruler. Shahji Bhonsale illustrates the bridge: he moved among Nizam Shahi, Mughal and Bijapuri contexts; the assigned source places a 5000 mansab and Poona jagirs in a particular Shah Jahan episode, while later claimant resistance operated with Bijapuri support. These are networks of service, not proof of permanent loyalty.

Qualification: local roots did not automatically yield a sovereign state, and later Shivaji's fort politics, legitimacy and administration need separate analysis. **Verdict:** the bridge explains resources and political learning; it should not erase contingency, diverse actors or the later distinctness of Maratha state formation.

Why this earns marks: It uses bargis, desh mukhs and Shahji while explicitly policing anachronism.

Mains 7. 15 marks | Was Jahangir's Deccan policy a failure? Answer in 200 words.

Directive alignment: assess both reverses and stated policy.

Model solution: Jahangir's Deccan record contains reverses, but describing it as simple failure misses a deliberate limited policy. Malik Ambar's recovery by 1610, Prince Parvez's inability to settle the contest and the 1611 command failure reveal the difficulty of consolidating Akbar's gains. Yet Khan-i-Khanan's alliance work and the 1616 victory over a combined Deccani force, followed by Prince Khurram's 1617 campaign, recovered Balaghat and brought the Ahmadnagar fort key.

Satish Chandra stresses that Jahangir did not enlarge Akbar's conquests after these successes because he sought to avoid deeper commitments and hoped moderation would stabilise neighbouring states. Diplomatic efforts to detach Bijapur, including farzand language, supported this design. This is a strategic choice with a cost: Malik Ambar resumed resistance and the political field remained unsettled; Bhatnari in 1624 exposed how quickly alliances could change.

Qualification: restraint did not erase logistical or fiscal constraints, and 'deliberate policy' should not become a claim that campaigns were easy. **Verdict:** Jahangir achieved limited recovery and wisely avoided annexation, but could not turn partial military success into a durable regional settlement.

Why this earns marks: It answers the evaluative directive using reverses, victories and the historian's policy interpretation.

Mains 8. 20 marks | Examine the 1636 Deccan settlement as a statesmanlike yet coercive system. Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: explain terms, system, benefits and limits.

Model solution: The 1636 settlement was statesmanlike because it replaced an expensive pursuit of direct expansion with a hierarchical buffer system; it was coercive because force and the extinction of Ahmadnagar structured the bargaining power. Shah Jahan had first ended the Nizam Shahi dynasty at Daulatabad in 1633, removing the principal unresolved northern-Deccan rival. He then did not annex Bijapur or Golconda.

Bijapur recognised Mughal suzerainty, paid an indemnity, promised non-interference in Golconda, accepted imperial arbitration of future disputes and agreed to cooperate in reducing Shahji or employ him away from the frontier. It received territory from Ahmadnagar. Golconda placed Shah Jahan's name in the khutba, removed the Iranian sovereign's name, accepted tribute and received Mughal protection. These terms display hierarchy without the province-level administration of direct annexation.

The arrangement lowered direct Mughal cost, stabilised the frontier and allowed Bijapur and Golconda to expand southward into Karnataka. It also gave the emperor an arbiter's role. However, the same ambiguity contained risk: tribute, protection and arbitration could be reinterpreted as claims to compensation and territorial extraction. The states retained military resources, courts and regional ambitions; they were buffers, not inert dependencies.

Qualification: no exact sum should be supplied without the treaty source, and khutba/sikka recognition alone must not be equated with total control. **Verdict:** 1636 was a pragmatic apex of limited imperialism, but its coercive hierarchy and unclear future limits made it vulnerable to the late 1650s reversal.

Why this earns marks: It explains both ahdnamas through a suzerainty-annexation distinction and reaches a graded conclusion.

Mains 9. 20 marks | Analyse why the 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem. Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: trace breakdown from settlement to dilemma and stop at 1657.

Model solution: The 1656-57 interventions reopened the Deccan problem because they abandoned the restraint that made the 1636 buffer settlement workable. In the decade after 1636, Bijapur and Golconda expanded southward, while the Mughals sometimes maintained neutrality and arbitrated disputes. By the late 1640s, Mughal financial strains in the Deccan, demands for a share of southern gains and the wish to draw powerful servants such as Shahji or Mir Jumla into imperial service altered incentives.

Against Golconda, dispute over tribute/exchange rates and compensation became a pretext for intervention in the Mir Jumla context. Against Bijapur, Muhammad Adil Shah's death, alleged arrears and political disorder opened a crisis. Aurangzeb pressed for more extensive annexation, whereas Shah Jahan's objectives were more variable; the source finds no conclusive basis for resolving every claim about Dara's role. The 1657 result compelled Bijapur to yield former Ahmadnagar areas, while Golconda faced demands over Karnataka-linked claims.

This was more than a campaign sequence: it told buffer states that protection could turn into extraction. It undermined trust, widened Mughal ambition and made a 'union of hearts' psychologically difficult in J. N. Sarkar's formulation.

Qualification: do not narrate the later succession war or Aurangzeb's full Deccan wars as though completed here.

Verdict: Shah Jahan inherited a settlement he had made workable, but late intervention converted its ambiguity into a longer dilemma of annexation versus cost.

Why this earns marks: It links finance, strategy, political debate and treaty credibility within the stipulated end date.

Mains 10. 20 marks | How should historians use sources to assess Mughal state capacity in the Deccan? Answer in 250 words.

Directive alignment: discuss method and apply it to capacity, not merely list sources.

Model solution: Mughal state capacity in the Deccan is best reconstructed by triangulation because each source type records a different claim rather than the whole field. Mughal Persian chronicles show how emperors represented hierarchy, victory and benevolent order; Abul Fazl's universal sovereignty language and Jahangir's court perspective are crucial, but court patronage can compress resistance. Deccani Persian histories recover rival courts and negotiations; Ferishta-like boundary claims need provenance rather than automatic cartographic acceptance.

Marathi records and later bakhars illuminate deshmukhs, revenue memories and mobile service networks. The attribution of measurement and zabti-type arrangements to Malik Ambar is valuable evidence of remembered state reconstruction, but later retrospective testimony cannot prove exact uniform assessment or a direct Todar Mal copy. Portuguese, Dutch and English reports help with ports, textiles and diplomacy yet privilege coastal commerce over inland command.

Material evidence checks narratives: Asirgarh and Daulatabad explain why siege and route control mattered; coins and khutba language illuminate sovereign claims; inscriptions and water systems can test urban or administrative assertions. Jahangir shooting Ambar's image should be read as imperial symbolism, not an event report.

Qualification: no source is discarded simply for bias; bias identifies purpose. **Verdict:** capacity was uneven and relational - strong enough to take forts and impose hierarchy, but dependent on supplies, local allies and credible settlements - a conclusion available only when textual claims are tested against one another and material settings.

Why this earns marks: It moves from genre to what it can/cannot prove and then applies the method to the historical argument.

Final solved-practice audit

Use this closing audit after comparing your own Mains attempt with the ten models. It is deliberately tied to the Deccan material rather than a generic answer-writing checklist.

1. Scope: Did the answer stop at 1657? A response on Shah Jahan may refer forward to the later dilemma, but it must not narrate the 1686-87 annexations or mature Mughal-Shivaji war as if those outcomes were already present. A response on the Maratha bridge must distinguish service networks from Shivaji's later state formation.

2. Thesis: Did the first two sentences take a position? For example, a 1636 answer should call the settlement both pragmatic and coercive, then promise to explain buffer advantages and credibility risks. A Malik Ambar answer should recognise both reconstruction/resistance and the limits of shifting alliance.

3. Evidence: Underline at least four named anchors in a 15-marker and at least six in a 20-marker. Strong anchors include the 1591 missions, Chand Bibi's Berar settlement, Asirgarh/Khandesh (1601), the 1611 coordination failure, 1616-17 recovery/restraint, Bhaturi (1624), Daulatabad (1633), the two 1636 ahdnamas and the 1656-57 breach. A date without a claim is not evidence.

4. Mechanism: After each anchor, answer 'what does this prove?' Khandesh proves route-logistics value; Ambar's mobile coalition proves why supply and local knowledge qualify conquest; khutba/tribute/arbitration prove suzerainty rather than annexation; the late interventions prove a problem of treaty credibility as well as territorial appetite.

5. Qualification: Add one precise caution, not a ritual caveat. Examples: Sonapat/Supa/Sonpet nomenclature must not become Haryana Sonipat; later Marathi evidence cannot prove a uniform Ambar revenue regime; a court painting is symbolic; a fort's fall is not instant territorial obedience; exact treaty sums need a source.

6. Verdict: End with a graded conclusion: Mughal power repeatedly achieved footholds and hierarchy but struggled to turn them into low-cost, credible and durable control. This final sentence should arise from the argument above, not be pasted onto it.

Completion standard: A high-quality response has directive fidelity, a visible chronological/causal spine, named evidence, source-aware qualification and a conclusion that rejects both 'total conquest' and 'total failure'. This completes the solved workbook.